

ADCLOD Podcast Series with Social Impact Founders

Episode 12: Shaheen Mistri, Teach For India

Neharika Vohra: Welcome to the ADCLOD podcast series with social impact founders, an initiative by the Ashank Desai Centre for Leadership and Organisational Development at IIM Ahmedabad, where we document and celebrate the leadership journeys of India's homegrown social entrepreneurs who have built impactful institutions from the ground up.

Neharika Vohra: In today's episode, we have the privilege of speaking with Shaheen Mistri, one of India's most enduring and visionary education leaders. Born in Mumbai, Shaheen grew up across 13 countries, and at 18 returned to the city and walked into the slums of Mumbai with a single question: why can't every child be as lucky as I have been? That question became Akanksha, founded in 1989 with 15 children and a group of college friends, which has grown into a network of 26 schools across Mumbai, Pune and Nagpur, reaching over 14,000 children today. Nearly two decades later, inspired by the Teach for America model and her meeting with Wendy Kopp, Shaheen co-founded Teach for India in 2008 with the audacious vision of providing an excellent education to every child in India. Today, Teach for India places over 1,000 fellows across eight cities, directly impacts 34,000 children, and has built an alumni community of over 4,600 members collectively reaching 50 million children indirectly. Shaheen is an Ashoka Fellow, a World Economic Forum Global Leader for Tomorrow, and an Asia Society 21 Leader. She is the author of **Redrawing India**, and has spoken at platforms across the world, from Davos to Delhi, on educational equity, leadership, and the transformative power of a child seen not as a problem to be fixed but as a partner in change.

Neharika Vohra: Shaheen, welcome to our podcast. It's a true honour to have you here.

Shaheen Mistri: Thank you so much. Lovely to be here.

Neharika Vohra: Shaheen, maybe we could start with you giving us a picture of what Teach for India looks like today — the scale, the cities you operate in, the nature of your fellows and staff, your alumni community, and how the organisation is funded.

Shaheen Mistri: Happy to. Teach for India is really a movement for educational equity — our focus is building a movement of leaders who work at every level of the system toward that single goal. Today we have around 1,200 fellows currently teaching; we brought in our largest-ever cohort this year, 720 incoming fellows currently in training. They teach across eight cities, and we've just launched our ninth, starting in Gurgaon this year, across roughly 300 schools. The fellowship itself is a two-year, full-time, intensive teaching experience where leadership is learned directly in the classroom. We now have 5,800 alumni of the programme, 70% of whom have stayed full-time in the social sector, working for children at various levels of the system.

Beyond the fellowship, we run what we call our movement-building programmes: Firki, a free online teacher training programme open to any teacher in India; the Kids Education Revolution, a student leadership movement that brings children together from across the world to reimagine education alongside their educators; and TFIIX, where we support entrepreneurs in some of the most remote parts of India to build their own versions of Teach for India, each building local leadership pipelines. Collectively, all of this is aimed at a North Star of building a movement of 50,000 leaders by 2032, who together transform the lives of one in ten children from lower-income backgrounds in the regions we serve.

Neharika Vohra: When you say 5,800 alumni — these are all your past fellows?

Shaheen Mistri: Yes, exactly — 5,800 people who've completed the two-year fellowship and now work across the country in different capacities.

Neharika Vohra: So in a sense, you're also building the workforce for the social sector more broadly.

Shaheen Mistri: Absolutely — that's really the core idea, and that's where the real multiplier lies. During the fellowship itself, they teach one group of children for two years, but as alumni, they go on to work at scale — with governments, running schools, and so on. Beyond that, we also have 16,000 student alumni who've come up through our own classrooms, some of whom go on to work in the sector themselves. In fact, over a hundred of our own former students have since cleared the fellowship's selection process and returned as Teach for India fellows themselves.

Neharika Vohra: To become a fellow, do you need to be a graduate?

Shaheen Mistri: Yes — our fellows are either recent graduates from various academic streams, or young professionals a few years into their careers who want to shift direction and enter the social sector.

Neharika Vohra: And how is most of this funded?

Shaheen Mistri: Entirely through donations. A large part of what my development team does year-round is fundraising — a significant share comes from CSR, with the rest from foundations and individuals.

Neharika Vohra: Have you ever felt that constant fundraising itself becomes a burden, or is it simply part of who you are at this point?

Shaheen Mistri: I feel very lucky to have a wonderful, stable team that carries much of that load, and an extremely active and supportive board — nationally, and also regional boards across all our cities. It really is a collective effort, and an ongoing one — you can never be entirely comfortable. But we've built genuine friendships and support over the years from people who care about the work, which has made it possible to do what we do. There's also often a real lag between starting a funding conversation and the money actually coming in, so it stays a constant work in progress.

Neharika Vohra: Are your funders mostly long-term, or is it more year-on-year?

Shaheen Mistri: Most make a long-term commitment in intent, but with yearly metrics attached — so nothing is ever fully guaranteed; you still have to meet specific goals annually with most funders to secure continued support.

Neharika Vohra: How do you see that tension — given that real change often doesn't show up on a year-by-year timeline?

Shaheen Mistri: Honestly, that's something I wish funders discussed and debated more, and found better ways around. I understand their constraints — their own reporting mechanisms are often built year-on-year — but this work doesn't always become visible on that timescale, and sometimes the pressure to show results pushes investment away from longer-term, less visible work, simply because it's harder to fund. We're lucky that with many of our donors, there's real ongoing conversation and partnership over multiple years — some are genuinely understanding of this, others are more constrained by their own institutional limits or lack the authority to bend on it. But it's a real challenge across the sector.

Neharika Vohra: Are there ways organisations like yours can structure funding so some goes toward the slower, patient work and some toward the more urgent, visible work?

Shaheen Mistri: We're actively trying to build up our reserves. The challenge is that our work — and our budget — is growing so quickly each year that raising enough to cover both current needs and a genuine reserve is difficult. Most Indian funders are also reluctant to fund reserves directly — it's simply not possible through CSR at all — so it's a harder conversation here than it tends to be in the US and some other countries, where the concept is more normalised. Indian funders generally want much more visibility into how money is spent, on a shorter timeframe. But building a larger reserve here would genuinely help the sector.

Neharika Vohra: That would also require a mindset shift from funders and organisations alike — how you account for it, how you stay transparent. Beyond funding, there's also the friction of working within government school systems, which have their own methods and priorities. How do you navigate that?

Shaheen Mistri: Honestly, my answer to almost everything comes down to relationships. The way we teach is different from the existing system, and there are a hundred factors already working against learning that the school itself contends with — and by entering these schools, we inherit many of the same challenges. It really depends on the relationship, and on the leadership of that particular school — a more open principal, someone who believes in a more holistic model of education, can navigate a lot of that friction and make the environment more conducive to learning. Sometimes we find that, sometimes we don't. It also depends heavily on the mindset our fellows bring in — if they arrive angry about what they're seeing children face, which is a very natural reaction at 22 or 23, that isn't always helpful. When they go in with more understanding of the people already working within the system, building relationships, recognising that change takes time and that much of what they're seeing reflects decades of social conditioning — when they bring humility and a spirit of partnership — we move faster.

Neharika Vohra: That must be part of how you train fellows, then — conditioning that kind of compassion.

Shaheen Mistri: It is, though it's genuinely difficult. I remember myself at 22 — I was a very angry, impatient young person, so I understand completely when they react that way.

Neharika Vohra: And that anger comes from a real place too — it's not something to simply disown.

Shaheen Mistri: Absolutely not — that anger is often what brings people into this work in the first place, and what keeps them in it. The real question is how you channel it productively. One of the things I've learned very slowly, and am still learning, is that partnership feels like a slower path, but it's ultimately a far more sustainable one.

Neharika Vohra: You mentioned you're about to enter Gurgaon — what does that process actually look like? Do you work with the district education authorities directly?

Shaheen Mistri: We place fellows in two kinds of schools. In government schools, we typically approach the relevant governing authority — the municipal commissioner, for example — for permission, and they place us where there are vacancies and genuine need, so we're never displacing existing teachers; we then make a long-term commitment to those schools. We also place fellows in some of the lowest-income private schools — the kind of budget schools that spring up in low-income communities, often with infrastructure significantly worse than government schools — and there we typically need to approach each school or trust individually for permission. At this point, our real challenge is the opposite of scarcity — we can't keep up with the demand on the ground for strong teachers.

Neharika Vohra: Through working with so many fellows and understanding what actually happens in classrooms, have you been able to influence policy at the level of teacher training or classroom practice, nationally or at the state level?

Shaheen Mistri: Think of Teach for India the organisation as one entity, and the wider alumni movement as the larger umbrella around it. The organisation itself doesn't work directly in policy, but what we do is spark that interest in our fellows, who then go on to do that work themselves. For instance, one of our staff alumni started a programme in Chennai called Mati Foundation, which now partners with the district collector on foundational literacy and numeracy across the whole of Tamil Nadu — genuinely working at scale. Another of our alumni, Santosh More from our Pune cohort, has started three organisations, the most recent being a movement for educational equity called Shikshagraha, which now brings together 18 organisations working toward a goal of impacting a million schools nationally. Many of our alumni also work behind the scenes with government. So the answer is yes, but it happens indirectly, and it takes time.

Neharika Vohra: So my sense is your stakeholders include the teachers and schools you work with, your fellows, your funders, and finally, the children in the classrooms. How does that all come together?

Shaheen Mistri: I'd actually say the child is our first stakeholder. It's an interesting model — in the short term, during the fellowship, the goal is for fellows to transform the lives of their own students, and in the long term, as alumni, they work with children at scale. So the fellow is a leader impacting children both immediately and over time. We take real responsibility for transforming children's lives — not just academically, but in terms of the life skills and values that improve not only their own lives but the lives of others around them. We hold a fairly broad definition of what education is actually for.

Neharika Vohra: One last question on the organisation itself — what's the size of the core team, separate from the fellows?

Shaheen Mistri: We're about 300 people, including full-time staff and consultants, plus a rotating group of interns — this team runs the fellowship, the movement-building programmes, and the entire back-end architecture that makes it all possible.

Neharika Vohra: Do these people tend to stay with you for a long time, or is there attrition? How do you keep them motivated?

Shaheen Mistri: Honestly, all of the above is true. Our leadership team is fairly tenured, which we're genuinely grateful for. The fellowship itself is designed as a two-year cycle, so we bring in new fellows every year, and attrition there is a real concern — it's an extremely difficult experience, and however transparent we try to be about the challenges beforehand, some people only realise once they're actually on the ground in a school that it isn't for them. On the staff side, we're also a fairly young organisation in terms of tenure, so we do see a lot of people join for three or four years before moving on to other things in the ecosystem — and honestly, we feel fine about that in many roles, because we see them going on to contribute to the wider ecosystem in different ways.

Neharika Vohra: For someone managing all of this, that must be fairly stressful — constantly training people, constantly bringing new people up to speed.

Shaheen Mistri: I think because our programme naturally runs in two-year cycles, the team has simply grown used to that rhythm — every year we run our training institute, and over 17 years we've built up a large base of documented training resources, tweaked annually, which helps enormously. Beyond that, we put a genuinely disproportionate amount of energy into building culture — talking about our values, creating space for them, hiring explicitly for values. Right through a staff member's life cycle with us, culture is an explicit area of focus, down to the specific culture we want present in a classroom.

Neharika Vohra: That's interesting — you're essentially trying to codify something that's usually treated as uncodifiable, so it transfers more easily from one person to the next.

Shaheen Mistri: Exactly. And for training, do you use in-house trainers or bring people in from outside?

Neharika Vohra: Both.

Shaheen Mistri: We have a very active, full-time training and support team in-house, who run the bulk of our training institute, and they also bring in outside experts regularly — so our fellows get a real blend of our own accumulated learning each year alongside fresh outside perspective.

Neharika Vohra: You met Wendy Kopp, and that's how Teach for India grew out of the Teach for America model. What's the relationship there now — do you still learn from each other, stay connected?

Shaheen Mistri: When we were starting Teach for India, Wendy was building a global network called Teach for All — today there are 64 countries with similar, independent organisations under that umbrella. We each run our own boards, our own fundraising, our own work, but we're bound by shared founding principles we all believe in deeply, and there's genuinely rich, well-curated cross-learning at multiple levels of the organisation — we meet often, travel to each other's countries, and our functional heads exchange ideas regularly. It's a very active learning network.

Neharika Vohra: Among those other 63 countries, which one operates at a similar scale to Teach for India?

Shaheen Mistri: Teach for America was the very first programme, started about 35 years ago, so it has a real head start and remains the largest. It was then replicated in the UK as Teach First, which I believe is slightly larger than Teach for India — I'd say Teach for India is the third largest in the network.

Neharika Vohra: Do they all follow broadly the same model?

Shaheen Mistri: There are plenty of local adaptations, but the core elements — recruiting top talent, having them teach for two years with children from low-income backgrounds, building an alumni movement, rigorous evaluation, strong training and support — you'll find across all of them.

Neharika Vohra: One of your other identities is having started Akanksha at 18, when you came back from dropping out of Tufts and began studying at Xavier College. What's Akanksha's relationship to Teach for India today?

Shaheen Mistri: Akanksha today is doing genuinely well — it's led by Sourav Taneja, a Teach for India fellow from our very first cohort, who's now Akanksha's CEO, which is its own nice full-circle moment. Akanksha has doubled down on running its own schools, but also works at fairly significant scale within the government school system, spreading some of its programmes more broadly — its art programme, for instance, has always been particularly strong, and has now reached hundreds of schools. The two organisations share some common trustees, so there's constant dialogue between us, and we place some Teach for India fellows within Akanksha's own schools. There's also a lot of thought partnership at the leadership level, among Akanksha and many of our other alumni-founded organisations — we regularly reach out to each other for support and ideas when we run into challenges. It's been a genuinely special relationship.

Neharika Vohra: Does Akanksha run its own schools entirely?

Shaheen Mistri: Akanksha partners with government to run public-private partnership schools — the building belongs to government, children are admitted by lottery, and Akanksha runs the entire school: hiring the teachers, the headmistress, everything. It's a genuinely strong partnership between government and Akanksha.

Neharika Vohra: You mentioned the arts have been a big part of the work, and the Maya musical too — what was the origin of bringing those into the school programme? It makes a lot of sense, but it's not something we hear about often in this space.

Shaheen Mistri: Honestly, I have a real soft spot for the arts — I grew up playing piano, with a lot of exposure to theatre, music and dance, and when I began working directly with children, I found the arts to be an extremely powerful — maybe the most powerful — way to help children find their voice, express themselves, and understand who they are. That conviction grew stronger at Akanksha, where we started a strong visual arts programme and then moved into theatre. I've now worked on seven musicals across both organisations, including Maya. The arts, for us, were never just about technique — they've always been a way of taking children through a deep, reflective journey around a concept or value. A couple of years ago, for instance, we worked on a musical called The Conference of the Birds, built around a two-year exploration of the idea of India and the values enshrined in our constitution's preamble — where do we see equality around us, where don't we see liberty — culminating in the musical itself. The larger idea is that our nation is really built in our classrooms, and if our children grow up compassionate, our country and our world will be more compassionate too.

Neharika Vohra: Let me ask about TFI's — and really Akanksha's — ultimate vision of educational equity for every child in India. What would a fully realised version of that look like, and what role do you see Teach for India playing in it, relative to

government, communities and other actors?

Shaheen Mistri: I often say that when I was much younger, I genuinely believed I could do enormous things myself. As I've gotten older, and hopefully a little wiser, that dream has actually come closer to me, in a way — because I've come to believe my real responsibility is simply to keep working on myself, and let whatever ripples out from that happen on its own. As I've come to understand how complex the world really is, I've also grown into more humility, and a clearer sense that we simply have to work together with a great many others toward any shared vision. If educational equity is truly achieved, and every child gets an excellent education, I think we'll have played a meaningful role in reaching an India free of poverty and filled with love — that, to me, is really the reason to change the education system in the first place. At that scale of vision, the honest answer is that everyone has to work toward it — government, civil society, all of it. Teach for India's specific contribution, I think, is our investment in talent — the belief that leaders genuinely matter. It sounds like an obvious point, but I've found the sector tends to focus heavily on programmes and products, and much less on the idea that the real multiplier is the leader. You see so many examples today, globally, of the damage a poor leader can do, and the power a genuinely great one can unlock. Our bet has really just been to focus deeply on leadership, and trust that it ripples outward toward that larger vision.

Neharika Vohra: I really hope that happens — that's certainly what one would want to see. You also said something interesting there, about focusing more on yourself now, trusting that it creates its own ripples. That's something many leaders instinctively sense, but rarely act on — we tend to keep focusing outward rather than inward. Could you say more about why a leader should focus on the self as much as, or more than, the outside world?

Shaheen Mistri: Honestly, everything I practice has really come from watching others do it first. I spent a lot of time over the years in an ecosystem in Ahmedabad called ServiceSpace, where people did and believed things that felt quite different from who I was at the time. Where I believed heavily in outcomes, they talked about planting seeds without worrying where those seeds went. Where I was searching for the big, fast route to a goal, they spoke about small acts done with a lot of love. It felt disorienting at first, but the more I saw the impact they were able to create without treating impact itself as the goal, the more I started to understand the real power in that. Over time it became almost a logical shift too — millions of people doing small things will always be bigger and more sustainable than a few people doing big things. I think the whole idea of leadership has shifted globally, away from the charismatic, front-of-the-room figure everyone follows, toward something more distributed — enabled by technology, closer to how nature itself operates — a many-to-many form of leadership, where sometimes you step forward and sometimes you hold space quietly at the back, but leadership genuinely flows in every direction, not just from one person outward. I was fortunate to observe a lot of leaders like that around me, and something in it resonated very strongly. Counterintuitively, the more I focused on small things — on managing my own emotions, my own way of seeing the world — the more seemed to shift around me. It's small steps, honestly, and not even always steps forward; there are plenty of days I feel like I'm moving backward. But it's genuinely empowering, because when you focus heavily on things outside yourself, you don't actually have control over them. In this conversation, for instance, all I can really do is share my views as honestly as I can — I have no control over what you take away from it, or what you ask next. Worrying about that feels like wasted energy. Turning that same energy toward myself is what actually lets me shift something real.

Neharika Vohra: Turning to you as a leader specifically — what keeps you motivated, over three decades of this work, and what have some of your lows and highs been?

Shaheen Mistri: Honestly, I love children — that's what's kept me here, and what brought me in originally. I still teach once a week, and it's genuinely my favourite day of the week; right now I'm teaching a class of grade seven and eight students, and over two years we're exploring the value of love and what that looks like in the world. Going back to a classroom every week, at every stage, alongside whatever else I'm doing, has always reminded me why I do this — I believe human potential really does determine where the world goes, and that starts with children. Seeing what kids are capable of, and what a good teacher can unlock in them, keeps me genuinely motivated. The other part of it is that, over time, I've come to believe deeply in people, and in the basic goodness in most people. I've been lucky to work alongside so many extraordinary people, and in a world where the news often feels overwhelming, almost like everything is on fire, knowing I work every day alongside people trying, in their own way, to do good for the people around them keeps me anchored. There are plenty of bad days, but never bad enough to make me question what I'm doing, or why — more just, today was hard, tomorrow will be better.

Neharika Vohra: I think you've really put your finger on something important — that when children feel loved and safe, their defences come down, and that's when they become genuinely open to learning. If a child is constantly in fight-or-flight mode, they'll never reach their real potential — they'll stay stuck in survival. What you're doing, creating love and safety for children, feels essential, and it's clearly something you carry through to your fellows and teachers too.

Shaheen Mistri: This idea of leading with love is really the most important message I'm trying to amplify, in every way I can — I run sessions on it with fellows, and I'm in the very early stages of writing a book called **The Pedagogy of Love**, which tries to move love away from being a fluffy, abstract concept and toward something concrete: the small actions in a classroom that make a child feel safe, that they belong, and that they can be challenged with genuine care. The single most consistent thing I've seen across 36 years of working in high-performing classrooms has been the presence of love. I probably have more energy for spreading that particular idea right now than for anything else — it genuinely changes how a teacher feels about teaching itself. When you're giving and receiving love, a classroom becomes a space of healing, of joy, of real acceptance — even a kind of valuing of mistakes and failure, an understanding that we have to accept each other as people first. So many other concepts come alive once you start exploring that question as a teacher.

Neharika Vohra: Could you give us one story where you've really seen this play out?

Shaheen Mistri: During the Maya musical journey, I worked with a group of students on a series of service-related activities, and one day we took them to an old age home in Mumbai, where most residents had amputated limbs. We gave the children a challenge — spend 90 minutes with one of the residents, then come back and talk about it. One of our students ended up talking with an elderly woman there — I was watching from a distance, and there was a lot of hand movement, a lot of laughter. When I got closer, I realised, ironically, that they didn't actually share a common language. I assumed she'd move on to someone else after a few minutes, the way I might have — but the interaction continued for the full 90 minutes. This student was 13 years old. Afterward, during our debrief, I asked her what they'd been talking about, and why she'd stayed engaged so long. She looked at me and said, "Didi, I learned something today — I learned that you can communicate beyond language." To me, that was a genuine moment of love and empathy — a reminder of how many dimensions of connection exist beyond language itself. There are so many stories like that.

Neharika Vohra: I can imagine.

Shaheen Mistri: I can tell you another, actually, from just yesterday, that really touched me. I was on a call with some teachers, and one of them shared that she'd hated her own school years ago, because she'd had boils on her body, and her teacher made her feel almost diseased — wouldn't let other children sit near her or play with her, and she was completely ostracised. She left school telling herself she'd never want to be a teacher. Years later, she ended up at Teach for India, and, almost ironically, was assigned a student, Manisha, with the exact same condition. The pain from the boils was so severe that this child couldn't eat on her own, so at lunchtime, the teacher would take the girl's tiffin and feed her, bite by bite. She described how that one simple act shifted the child's entire experience of school. It's so often not the big, dramatic gestures — it's these small things, done when a child least expects them. There are so many stories like that.

Neharika Vohra: Looking back across three decades, do you have any regrets — anything you'd do differently with the benefit of hindsight?

Shaheen Mistri: I don't think I have regrets, because I think you almost have to go through the journey to arrive at the learning itself. That said, there's a lot I've learned in just the last five or ten years that I sometimes wish I'd known as a much younger person. Even something as basic as believing I personally could do enormous amounts, versus how I feel today — much smaller in the world, in a good way, with a much deeper sense that the collective matters, that working with others matters. As a young person I wanted to do everything myself, wanted to be in control; today I'm trying to learn to let go of that. There have been a lot of shifts like that along the way — even this idea of holding the grey areas of the world. I used to be a much more black-and-white person, believed strongly in simple notions of right and wrong. Today it feels far more nuanced and complex than that, and I believe much more in simply embracing being human — which, to me, means being flawed, knowing that on any given day there are things we could have done better, and that that's okay.

Neharika Vohra: That's very powerful, actually, because it's important for someone with your achievements to still speak openly about not being perfect — there's so much pressure right now to appear that way, and it simply isn't possible. Thank you for sharing that. I wanted to ask about your principal at Xavier's, Father D'Souza — I understand he admitted you on the condition that you promised to do something for India. Have you stayed in touch, and how do you think he sees you today?

Shaheen Mistri: I haven't been in touch with him in a long time, but I never forgot that commitment. It mattered less to me whether he ever saw the outcome, and more that I actually lived it out. I didn't get into Xavier's through the normal admissions process — he very kindly offered me one of, I think, five seats he had discretion over for what you might call outlier students, and I suppose I fell into that category. I took that commitment and that privilege very seriously.

Neharika Vohra: In a way, he did for you exactly what you now try to do for children — made you feel seen, made you feel special, and gave you a real opportunity.

Shaheen Mistri: Maybe — or maybe I just started crying in his office and he felt sorry for me.

Neharika Vohra: Either way. Succession planning is a known vulnerability across the Indian social sector — you're TFI's founding CEO, and I hope you continue this work for a long time yet, but have you thought about succession, and how do you approach it?

Shaheen Mistri: Very actively, actually — I feel lucky to have a board that keeps me genuinely focused on issues like this. I don't feel especially worried about succession at TFI, because we're literally in the business of building leadership, and I feel genuinely blessed by the team I work with — I can already picture a handful of people who could take this forward, each bringing their own strengths and likely taking the organisation in slightly different directions. I've had the privilege of working with a number of people who've genuinely grown up within TFI over the last 10, 12, even 15 years, alongside me. We think about it actively — we have a full succession planning document that goes before our HR subcommittee — but beyond the document, it really comes down to a strong belief that we have genuinely good people who will carry this forward, because they believe in the mission themselves, in their hearts. I feel very sure of that.

Neharika Vohra: Finally — for listeners who might be considering a career change, or are at a point of making choices about where their careers should go, both young people and those already in other jobs — what would you tell them, based on your own experience?

Shaheen Mistri: Great question. First, I'd say: just come. Don't overthink it — often the most important thing you can do is take that first step. A good starting point, especially if you're coming from a different sector, however experienced or successful you've been elsewhere, is to recognise that this is a genuinely different world. So start by doing something that puts you close to the ground — in our case, since we work in education, that means direct work with children or teachers, understanding the complexity, the nuance, the emotional toll of driving change at ground level. That feels like the right starting point. From there, once you've built that context and understanding, look for the sweet spot between the skills you're bringing in and the context you've actually arrived in.

Neharika Vohra: Lovely, thank you. It's been such a pleasure speaking with you, Shaheen. We wish you all the best for the work you do, and I hope this conversation gives people ideas about how to lead organisations like this. Thank you so much.

Shaheen Mistri: Thank you so much — it's always a real privilege to have the space to step back and think about the journey. I really appreciate it. Thank you.